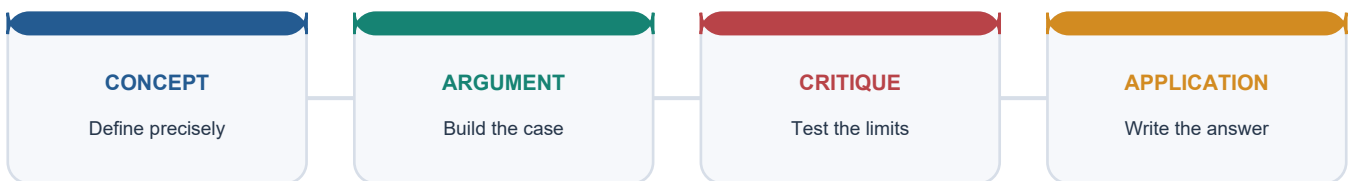


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Schools of Vedānta - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Schools of Vedānta - Solved Practice Workbook	3
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	3
Practice protocol	3
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	19
VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - 20 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS	19
ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE	33

Schools of Vedānta - Solved Practice Workbook

How to use this workbook. Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed independently for each question from a randomised draw, so no rotation or predictable sequence can be exploited. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The solved previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.

Contents. 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial drills, then 20 solved previous-year questions - every part primary-owned by syllabus item 19 across 2018-2025 - followed by six original solved Mains models at 2 x 10, 2 x 15 and 2 x 20 marks.

Declared answer bands. 10 marks: 150-200 words. 15 marks: 250-300 words. 20 marks: 340-400 words. Every solved answer below states its exact word count.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct position was fixed **independently for each question** from a randomised draw, so there is no rotation, cycle or seed-derived sequence to exploit; the four positions occur eight times each and twice in every consecutive block of eight, no position repeats on consecutive questions, and no window of four items forms an A->B->C->D rotation or an ABAB alternation. Option length, specificity, grammar and formatting are balanced so that the correct answer is not visually identifiable; the key is the longest option in only a minority of items and every distractor carries comparable doctrinal detail.

Composition: 24 core diagnostics (items 1-24) covering all nineteen teaching sessions, then 8 remedial drills (items 25-32) targeting the errors this topic reliably produces.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS

MCQ 1. What makes Vedānta plural

Which statement best explains why one canon produced six commentarial schools?

A. The schools accept different scriptures, so their conclusions about the absolute must differ B. Bādarāyaṇa's aphorisms already contain three finished systems that later teachers merely restated C. The Upaniṣads contain only identity-sentences, so difference had to be imported from outside D. The canon is shared but its compact aphorisms under-determine which sentences are read literally

Answer: D. The canon is shared but its compact aphorisms under-determine which sentences are read literally

- **A:** All six schools comment on the same threefold canon of Upaniṣads, Gītā and Brahma Sūtra, which is exactly why no school can win by citing a text the others reject.
- **B:** The aphorisms are compact and do not contain later school-formulations ready-made; that under-determination is the structural cause of divergence, not a hidden completeness.
- **C:** The Upaniṣads contain both identity-sentences and difference-sentences, and the whole hermeneutic problem is which set governs the reading of the other.
- **D:** Correct - a shared, unamendable canon plus aphorisms that do not settle the literal-versus-secondary question forces each commentator to supply a metaphysics that saves the remaining sentences.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates write that the schools "differ about scripture," which is false and unrewarded; the marks lie in saying they agree about scripture and differ about its interpretation.

MCQ 2. The two definitions of the absolute

Consider the following statements about the Vedāntic definitions of ultimate reality.

1. The essential definition (**svarūpa-lakṣaṇa**) states its intrinsic nature as being-consciousness-bliss.
2. The relational definition (**taṭastha-lakṣaṇa**) indicates it as that from which origin, sustenance and dissolution proceed.
3. The relational definition is used to state what the absolute is in itself, and the essential definition to explain its cosmological role.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 3 only, since both definitions ultimately describe intrinsic nature B. Statements 1 and 2 only, because statement 3 reverses the function of the two definitions C. Statement 2 only, as being-consciousness-bliss is a list of attributes rather than an essence D. All three statements, because the two definitions are interchangeable in Vedāntic usage

Answer: B. Statements 1 and 2 only, because statement 3 reverses the function of the two definitions

- **A:** Retains the correct first statement but keeps the reversal in the third, and also misdescribes the relational definition, which deliberately identifies by relation rather than by nature.
- **B:** Correct - the essential definition says what the absolute is, the relational definition says why it is called the ground of the world, and statement 3 swaps those roles.
- **C:** Being-consciousness-bliss is presented as expressing the very essence, not as a set of accidental predicates added to a substrate.
- **D:** Interchangeability would destroy the division of labour that lets an answer supply both a metaphysics and a cosmology from one doctrine.

Examiner trap 2: Answers give only the essential definition and then try to explain world-causation from it, losing the relational definition that alone licenses calling the absolute the ground of origin, sustenance and dissolution.

MCQ 3. Qualityless and qualified

Which statement correctly represents the three schools on whether the absolute has determinate attributes?

A. Advaita denies limiting attributes but affirms essence; Rāmānuja affirms infinite auspicious qualities; Madhva adds independence B. Advaita denies all nature whatsoever; Rāmānuja accepts both a qualityless and a qualified level; Madhva accepts only the qualityless level C. Advaita and Rāmānuja agree that the absolute is qualityless; Madhva alone treats it as personal, qualified and worshipful D. All three schools accept a qualityless level above the personal Lord, differing only about whether that level can be worshipped

Answer: A. Advaita denies limiting attributes but affirms essence; Rāmānuja affirms infinite auspicious qualities; Madhva adds independence

- **A:** Correct - qualityless means free of limiting, relational and objectifiable attributes while being-consciousness-bliss remains the essence; Rāmānuja's absolute is qualified by infinite auspicious qualities; Madhva's is qualified and above all independent.
- **B:** Contains the two commonest errors at once: it turns qualitylessness into blankness and credits Rāmānuja with a two-level scheme he explicitly rejects.
- **C:** Rāmānuja rejects any qualityless level above the personal Lord, so pairing him with Advaita on this point inverts his central objection.
- **D:** Only Advaita admits a qualityless level; for the other two there is no such level for worship to be measured against.

Examiner trap 3: The sentence "Rāmānuja accepts both nirguṇa and saguṇa Brahman" is written almost reflexively and destroys the answer, because his entire critique presupposes that no level lies above the personal Lord.

MCQ 4. Efficient and material causality

Which school-and-position pairing on the world's causes is correct?

A. Advaita makes the absolute the efficient cause only, with ignorance supplying the material cause B. Rāmānuja makes God the efficient cause and dependent primordial matter the material cause C. Madhva makes God the efficient cause and dependent primordial matter the material cause D. Nyāya makes God both efficient and material cause, unlike every Vedānta school

Answer: C. Madhva makes God the efficient cause and dependent primordial matter the material cause

- **A:** Advaita makes the absolute both causes precisely because no second material can exist; ignorance is the explanation of appearance, not an independent stuff alongside the absolute.
- **B:** This is Madhva's position, not Rāmānuja's; Rāmānuja makes the absolute both causes through the real transformation of its non-conscious mode.
- **C:** Correct - for Madhva God is efficient cause, primordial matter is the real dependent material cause, and universal dependence coexists with real eternal difference.
- **D:** Nyāya assigns efficient causality to God and material causality to eternal atoms, which is the very split Vedānta claims to overcome.

Examiner trap 4: The formula "Brahman is both efficient and material cause" is applied to all of Vedānta, whereas it holds for Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita in different senses and is denied by Madhva.

MCQ 5. Why the instrument list is six and then restricted

Which statement best captures Advaita's position on the means of valid knowledge?

A. Six are accepted, all confined to the empirical level, and testimony alone discloses the absolute B. Three are accepted, and inference is treated as the principal route to the non-objective absolute C. Six are accepted, and all six retain their full validity even after the absolute has been realised D. Perception is rejected outright, because the world that perception presents is dependently real

Answer: A. Six are accepted, all confined to the empirical level, and testimony alone discloses the absolute

- **A:** Correct - the Bhāṭṭa list of six is retained, the triad of knower, means and known confines all six to the empirical order, and revelation removes ignorance and lapses with it, as the clearing-nut settles with the mud.
- **B:** Three is the Viśiṣṭādvaita and Dvaita count, and inference is expressly disqualified because there is no perceived instance of the absolute and no mark uniquely co-present with it.
- **C:** Post-realisation survival of the instruments would leave a residual duality of knower and known, which is precisely what the non-dual thesis forbids.
- **D:** Perception is denied ultimacy, not empirical validity; the world it presents is publicly valid and law-governed at its own level.

Examiner trap 5: Writing that Advaita "rejects perception and inference" converts a two-level epistemology into scepticism and forfeits the distinction between denying ultimacy and denying validity.

MCQ 6. Rāmānuja on indeterminate perception

What exactly does Rāmānuja reject in the theory of indeterminate perception?

A. He rejects indeterminate perception altogether, holding that every cognition is essentially verbal B. He accepts indeterminate perception but denies that any cognition grasps a qualifierless object C. He accepts indeterminate perception and holds that it does grasp a wholly qualifierless object D. He treats indeterminate and determinate perception as two names for one undifferentiated act

Answer: B. He accepts indeterminate perception but denies that any cognition grasps a qualifierless object

- **A:** He does not abolish indeterminate perception; he redefines it as the first cognition of an individual already apprehended with its configuration.
- **B:** Correct - his thesis that all cognition is of the qualified is aimed at the possibility of a qualifierless object, which is why the qualityless absolute cannot be established by perception.
- **C:** This would concede exactly what his argument denies, and would leave Advaita's absolute epistemically available.
- **D:** He distinguishes them by order and content: the first cognition grasps the individual with its structure, the later one additionally recognises the generic character as recurrent.

Examiner trap 6: Candidates report that Rāmānuja "denies nirvikalpaka perception," which misstates a redefinition as a rejection and loses the precise target of his argument.

MCQ 7. Placing the Lord

Which sequence correctly matches each school to its placement of the Lord?

A. Advaita - the Lord is the final truth; Viśiṣṭādvaita - the Lord is provisional; Dvaita - the Lord is a mode B. Advaita - the Lord is unreal; Viśiṣṭādvaita - the Lord is only a world-soul; Dvaita - the Lord is one independent among many C. Advaita - the Lord is a semblance without cosmic function; Viśiṣṭādvaita - the Lord is qualityless; Dvaita - the Lord is dependent D. Advaita - the Lord is conditioned by illusion; Viśiṣṭādvaita - the Lord is the absolute; Dvaita - the Lord alone is independent

Answer: D. Advaita - the Lord is conditioned by illusion; Viśiṣṭādvaita - the Lord is the absolute; Dvaita - the Lord alone is independent

- **A:** Inverts Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita, and turns Madhva's supremely independent God into a mode, which is the one status his system exists to deny.
- **B:** "Unreal" misstates a placement that is fully real at the empirical level, and Madhva admits exactly one independent reality, not several.
- **C:** In Advaita the Lord is precisely the cosmically functioning creator and moral governor at the empirical level, and Rāmānuja's Lord is qualified, never qualityless.
- **D:** Correct - conditioned by illusion, identical with the absolute, and uniquely independent are the three placements, and each generates that school's account of devotion.

Examiner trap 7: Writing that "Advaita denies God" ignores that Advaita affirms the Lord as fully real at the empirical level and denies only ultimacy, which is the distinction the examiner is testing.

MCQ 8. The witness and the three states

Which statement correctly represents Advaita's argument from the three states of experience?

A. The report from deep sleep proves non-dual identity in a way that every rival school must accept B. The fourth standpoint is a further temporal episode that follows the state of deep sleep itself C. The report "I slept peacefully; I knew nothing" presupposes continuity and supports a witness D. In deep sleep the witness itself lapses, which is why the sleeper reports having known nothing

Answer: C. The report "I slept peacefully; I knew nothing" presupposes continuity and supports a witness

- **A:** The inference is school-relative; Rāmānuja and Nyāya accept an enduring self while rejecting its identity with the non-dual absolute, so presenting it as neutral proof overstates it.
- **B:** The fourth standpoint is not another episode in a temporal series but the consciousness that underlies and illumines waking, dream and deep sleep alike.
- **C:** Correct - a report about a period without object-cognition requires something that did not lapse during it, which is why manifestation is assigned to consciousness rather than to any mental state.
- **D:** If the witness lapsed there would be nothing to ground the later report, and the argument would collapse into the very discontinuity it is designed to exclude.

Examiner trap 8: The deep-sleep argument is presented as a knock-down proof of non-duality, when its honest strength is that it establishes an enduring witness and leaves the identity-claim to be argued separately.

MCQ 9. Three non-dual models of individuality

Which pairing of model, associated name and image is correct?

A. Limitation with Vācaspati Miśra and pot-space; reflection with Padmapāda and the mirrored face B. Limitation with Padmapāda and the mirrored face; reflection with Vācaspati Miśra and pot-space C. Semblance with Vācaspati Miśra and the mirrored face; limitation with Padmapāda and pot-space D. Reflection with Vācaspati Miśra and pot-space; semblance with Padmapāda and the mirrored face

Answer: A. Limitation with Vācaspati Miśra and pot-space; reflection with Padmapāda and the mirrored face

- **A:** Correct - delimitation by adjuncts is illustrated by one space appearing as many pot-spaces, while reflection in ignorance is illustrated by one face yielding many images.
- **B:** Exchanges both the names and the images, so every element of the pairing is displaced by one position.
- **C:** Attaches the semblance model to the wrong expositor and gives it the reflection image, while assigning the limitation image to the reflection line.
- **D:** Gives the reflection model the limitation image and leaves the semblance model, which stresses ontological thinness, attached to a reflection analogy.

Examiner trap 9: Because both models explain the same fact, candidates attach either name to either model, and the pot-space and mirror images are then swapped along with them.

MCQ 10. Rāmānuja's device for a wide-knowing atomic self

Why does an atomic self in Viśiṣṭādvaita not have a correspondingly narrow range of cognition?

A. Because the self physically expands in exact proportion to the number of objects it is knowing B. Because atomicity is a property only of the liberated self and never of the self while it is bound C. Because attributive consciousness is a quality of the self that reveals objects and can extend D. Because the self temporarily borrows the Lord's omniscience during every single act of knowing

Answer: C. Because attributive consciousness is a quality of the self that reveals objects and can extend

- **A:** No physical expansion is proposed; the substantive self remains atomic and the extension belongs to its revealing quality.
- **B:** Atomicity characterises the self as such; what differs between bondage and liberation is the degree of karmic obstruction on its attributive consciousness.
- **C:** Correct - attributive consciousness contracts under karmic obstruction and expands without obstruction in liberation, so cognitive reach is decoupled from the size of the knower.
- **D:** Borrowed omniscience would erase the self's status as a real knower and would make every cognition a divine act rather than the self's own.

Examiner trap 10: Answers state that the self is atomic and then describe it as knowing distant objects without naming attributive consciousness, leaving an apparent contradiction where a precise doctrine exists.

MCQ 11. Grades of reality

Which statement about the status of the world in Advaita Vedānta is correct?

A. The world is wholly non-existent, like a hare's horn, and appears only through the misuse of language B. The world is dependently real: denied absolute reality but retaining public, law-governed validity C. The world is ultimately real but is temporarily hidden from us by the concealing power of ignorance D. The world occupies the apparent level of reality along with dream objects and the shell-silver illusion

Answer: B. The world is dependently real: denied absolute reality but retaining public, law-governed validity

- **A:** What is wholly non-existent never appears at all, whereas the world appears, coheres and supports action, which is exactly the difference the doctrine is built to mark.
- **B:** Correct - the middle grade denies independence while preserving empirical functioning, which is why sublation by knowledge of the absolute is possible without collapsing into nihilism.
- **C:** Ultimacy is precisely what is withheld; concealment explains why the absolute is not recognised, not why an ultimately real world is hidden.
- **D:** The apparent level covers private, within-experience cancellations such as dream and shell-silver, while the world holds the empirical level with intersubjective validity.

Examiner trap 11: Collapsing the middle grade into either of the outer two produces either realism or nihilism, and the single sentence "the world is unreal" is the commonest way candidates do it.

MCQ 12. Apparent transformation and real transformation

What is the best verdict on the claim that apparent transformation is the logical development of real transformation?

A. It is straightforwardly true, since both doctrines assert that the effect really pre-exists in the cause B. It is straightforwardly false, since the two doctrines share no premise whatever C. It is partly true: the structure of cause-dependence is inherited, but the commitment to real change is abandoned D. The question cannot be answered, since real transformation belongs to Sāṃkhya and comparison across schools is illegitimate

Answer: C. It is partly true: the structure of cause-dependence is inherited, but the commitment to real change is abandoned

- **A:** Pre-existence is shared, but real transformation additionally requires genuine modification of the cause, which apparent transformation denies outright.
- **B:** Both refuse production from nothing and both make the effect cause-dependent, so the shared architecture is real and cannot be waved away.
- **C:** Correct - agreement is structural and disagreement is ontological, which is why milk-into-curd and rope-into-snake give the effect contrary grades of reality.
- **D:** Cross-school comparison is precisely what the printed question invites, and Advaita itself develops its position by arguing against real transformation.

Examiner trap 12: The word "development" is treated as a yes-or-no prompt, so candidates commit to one side and forfeit the graded verdict that the question is actually testing.

MCQ 13. Two powers and two locations

Which statement about illusion and ignorance is the most defensible?

A. In many formulations illusion is cosmic and linked to the Lord, ignorance individual, though usage varies B. Illusion and ignorance are strictly synonymous terms in every Advaita text without any exception at all C. Illusion belongs to the individual self and ignorance to the Lord, reversing the usual textual association D. Ignorance is a mere absence of knowledge and therefore exercises no positive function whatever in bondage

Answer: A. In many formulations illusion is cosmic and linked to the Lord, ignorance individual, though usage varies

- **A:** Correct - the cosmic and individual association is the standard exam formula, and the honest qualification that sources are not uniform is itself part of the correct answer.
- **B:** Strict synonymy is one usage among several, and asserting it as universal removes a distinction that examiners repeatedly test.
- **C:** The association runs the other way; reversing it also breaks the link between illusion and the Lord's cosmic function.
- **D:** Ignorance is held to be positive in form, since a bare absence could not perform both concealment and projection.

Examiner trap 13: Candidates either flatten the two terms into synonyms or assert a rigid distinction as though it were universal; the mark-earning answer states the distinction and records the variation.

MCQ 14. Two indescribabilities

How do the indescribability of the absolute and the indescribability of illusion differ from one another?

A. They mean the same thing, namely that neither can ever become an object of any means of valid knowledge B. The absolute is indescribable because it is sublated, while illusion is indescribable because it is never sublated C. The absolute is indescribable because we lack the vocabulary, while illusion is indescribable because it is unreal D. The absolute exceeds predication and is never sublated; illusion is indeterminate because experienced yet sublated

Answer: D. The absolute exceeds predication and is never sublated; illusion is indeterminate because experienced yet sublated

- **A:** Treating the two as one meaning erases the difference between a surplus that resists predication and an indeterminacy that resists classification.
- **B:** This reverses both halves: the absolute is the unsublated reality, and it is illusion whose products are sublated by knowledge.
- **C:** Vocabulary is not the issue; the absolute is non-objectifiable in principle, and illusion is not unreal, since sheer non-being could never appear.
- **D:** Correct - one term marks what lies beyond the categories, the other marks what falls between them, and only the first is readily conceded by realist rivals.

Examiner trap 14: The single word "indescribable" is treated as one doctrine, so the answer describes illusion twice and never states the absolute's non-objectifiability at all.

MCQ 15. Where the seven objections bite hardest

On which two objections is Advaita generally regarded as most vulnerable, and for what reason?

A. Concealment and cessation, because both of these replies depend entirely on the rope-snake model B. Locus and means of knowing, because the seat and proof of ignorance presuppose Advaita's standpoint C. Nature and indefinability, because both of them happen to be answered by the very same trichotomy D. Remover and cessation, because the undivided-form mental mode is admittedly a later formulation

Answer: B. Locus and means of knowing, because the seat and proof of ignorance presuppose Advaita's standpoint

- **A:** These are the two on which Advaita answers most convincingly, since the logic of sublation applies directly to both.
- **B:** Correct - two Advaita sub-schools answer the locus question differently, and the disputed datum "I do not know" can be read as a mere absence, so both leave a genuine residue.
- **C:** Being answered by one trichotomy is not itself a weakness; the weakness there is the prior acceptance of sublatability, which is a different point.
- **D:** Lateness of a formulation is a caution about attribution, not a defeat of the reply; the removal-objection is answered adequately within the ladder-model.

Examiner trap 15: All seven objections are listed with equal weight and no verdict, so a question that says "examine" is answered as though it said "enumerate."

MCQ 16. Superimposition and the theory of error

Which statement correctly relates superimposition to the indescribable-error theory?

A. They are simply two names for one and the same doctrine, one given in Sanskrit and one in English B. Superimposition explains the status of the erroneous object, while the error-theory names the process C. The error-theory applies only to shell-silver illusions, while superimposition applies only to the world D. Superimposition is the process of mutual transference; the error-theory states the object's status

Answer: D. Superimposition is the process of mutual transference; the error-theory states the object's status

- **A:** They are distinct doctrines that must be connected but not conflated, and the distinction is regularly examined.
- **B:** This reverses the two roles: the process is superimposition, and the status of the product is what the error-theory supplies.
- **C:** Both operate at both scales, which is the point of saying that what shell-silver is to shell, the world is to the absolute.
- **D:** Correct - the transference of attributes between self and not-self is the process, and calling the presented object neither real nor unreal is the accompanying ontology.

Examiner trap 16: Answers use the two terms interchangeably in one paragraph, which makes the argument circular: the error is explained by the process and the process by the error.

MCQ 17. The great sentence

How does Advaita make the great sentence "that thou art" philosophically intelligible?

A. By taking both words in their full direct meanings and then asserting their strict literal identity B. By abandoning both direct meanings entirely and substituting a purely figurative and poetic sense C. By abandoning the incompatible portions of both direct meanings and retaining the implied meaning D. By treating the sentence as an injunction to meditate rather than as a statement of accomplished fact

Answer: C. By abandoning the incompatible portions of both direct meanings and retaining the implied meaning

- **A:** Literal identity is impossible, since omniscience and cosmic causality cannot be the same as finitude, agency and ignorance.
- **B:** Total abandonment would leave a figure of speech rather than an identity, and Advaita needs strict identity of essence.
- **C:** Correct - part-abandoning implication drops the conflicting portions and keeps pure consciousness, exactly as "this is that Devadatta" drops then-there and now-here and keeps the person.
- **D:** Reading it as an injunction is the earlier-Mīmāṃsā style of subordinating statements of fact to action, which Advaita expressly resists.

Examiner trap 17: The Devadatta parallel is quoted as decoration rather than as the argument, so the answer names the device without ever showing what is dropped and what is kept.

MCQ 18. Comparing the three liberations

Which row correctly pairs each school with its own account of liberation?

A. Advaita - eternal service with graded bliss; Viśiṣṭādvaita - recognition of identity; Dvaita - communion without identity
B. Advaita - communion without identity; Viśiṣṭādvaita - eternal service with graded bliss; Dvaita - recognition of identity
C. Advaita - recognition of identity; Viśiṣṭādvaita - eternal service with graded bliss; Dvaita - communion without identity
D. Advaita - recognition of identity; Viśiṣṭādvaita - communion without identity; Dvaita - eternal service with graded bliss

Answer: D. Advaita - recognition of identity; Viśiṣṭādvaita - communion without identity; Dvaita - eternal service with graded bliss

- **A:** Rotates all three positions by two places, giving Advaita the doctrine of graded bliss that belongs only to Madhva.
- **B:** Rotates all three by one place and leaves recognition, which is Advaita's distinctive claim, attached to a school that denies identity outright.
- **C:** Right about Advaita but exchanges the other two, attaching gradation to Rāmānuja, who holds liberated souls alike in essential type.
- **D:** Correct - removal of ignorance yields recognition, unobstructed attributive consciousness yields communion, and permanent difference yields graded eternal service.

Examiner trap 18: Because all three involve knowledge, devotion or both, candidates conclude that the schools "broadly agree," which is precisely the flattening the 2022 comparison penalises.

MCQ 19. Inseparable dependence

Which statement about the doctrine of inseparable dependence is correct?

A. Selves and matter are real, distinct, and incapable of existing or being conceived apart from the absolute
B. Selves and matter are numerically identical with the absolute once liberating knowledge has been attained
C. Selves and matter are independent substances related to the absolute only by external efficient causality
D. Selves and matter are dependent appearances that vanish altogether on the dawning of liberating knowledge

Answer: A. Selves and matter are real, distinct, and incapable of existing or being conceived apart from the absolute

- **A:** Correct - the relation is stronger than a conceptual link and weaker than identity, which is exactly what allows real plurality inside a single substantive whole.
- **B:** Numerical identity is what Rāmānuja denies; treating modes as identical with their substance would collapse his system into the position he attacks.
- **C:** Independence is denied, and the relation is one of inseparable qualification rather than external causal production.
- **D:** Vanishing appearances is the Advaita account he replaces; his modes are real and are not cancelled by liberation.

Examiner trap 19: Candidates paraphrase the doctrine as "a kind of oneness," which quietly converts an inseparable qualifier into an identity and loses the school's entire middle position.

MCQ 20. Fivefold difference

Which set correctly names the five real and eternal differences?

A. God-soul, God-world, soul-world, world-time, and soul-time differences B. God-soul, soul-soul, God-matter, matter-time, and soul-time differences C. Soul-God, soul-soul, soul-matter, God-matter, matter-matter D. Soul-God, soul-matter, God-matter, God-time, and matter-matter differences

Answer: C. Soul-God, soul-soul, soul-matter, God-matter, matter-matter

- **A:** Omits both internal differences, which are the members that make plurality irreducible, and introduces time as a relatum that the doctrine does not use.
- **B:** Retains soul-soul but drops soul-matter and matter-matter, and again imports time into the scheme.
- **C:** Correct - the two internal differences among souls and among material things are as ultimate as the three cross-category ones, and they carry the doctrine's distinctive consequences.
- **D:** Drops difference among souls, which is the member that underwrites gradation in liberation, and adds a God-time pair that is not part of the fivefold list.

Examiner trap 20: The doctrine is reduced to "difference between God and world," which is compatible with qualified non-dualism as well and therefore proves nothing distinctive about Dvaita.

MCQ 21. Nimbārka on matter

According to the standard classification, non-conscious reality in Nimbārka's system includes which items?

A. Ordinary primordial matter, the internal organ, and the great sentences B. Ordinary primordial matter, non-prakritic divine substance, and time C. Ordinary primordial matter, atoms, and the unseen potency of ritual D. Ordinary primordial matter, divine substance, and the individual self

Answer: B. Ordinary primordial matter, non-prakritic divine substance, and time

- **A:** The internal organ is a product within material nature, and the great sentences belong to scripture rather than to the ontology of the non-conscious.
- **B:** Correct - the threefold classification is ordinary material nature and its products, non-prakritic substance associated with the divine realm, and time, with the caution that expositions vary on the placement of time.
- **C:** Atoms belong to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika cosmology, and unseen ritual potency belongs to Mīmāṃsā, so both are imports from other systems.
- **D:** The individual self is conscious by definition and therefore cannot be listed under the non-conscious.

Examiner trap 21: Candidates invent extra subtypes to fill the answer, when the required move is to state the adopted threefold classification and record that terminology varies.

MCQ 22. The chief-wrestler debate

Why is Sāṃkhya treated as Advaita Vedānta's chief metaphysical rival?

- A. Because it denies that the effect pre-exists in its cause and so threatens the whole of Vedāntic causation
- B. Because it accepts the authority of revealed scripture even more strictly than the Vedāntins themselves do
- C. Because it makes liberation depend upon the performance of ritual action rather than upon discriminative knowledge
- D. Because it is a close rival: it accepts pre-existence and one material ground, but makes that ground unconscious

Answer: D. Because it is a close rival: it accepts pre-existence and one material ground, but makes that ground unconscious

- **A:** Sāṃkhya is the classical defender of the pre-existence of the effect, which is precisely the premise it shares with Vedānta in transformed fashion.
- **B:** Its distinctive commitments are argued largely on independent grounds, and Śaṅkara's charge is that it cannot claim full scriptural support for a dual ontology.
- **C:** Sāṃkhya makes liberation turn on discriminative knowledge, which is another point of closeness rather than of divergence.
- **D:** Correct - proximity in architecture with divergence on the consciousness of the ground is exactly what makes it the decisive match.

Examiner trap 22: Sāṃkhya is dismissed as "atheistic materialism," which both misdescribes it and destroys the point that its danger lies in how much it shares with Vedānta.

MCQ 23. Consequences of absolutism

Which statement most accurately expresses the consequence of non-dual absolutism for ethical life?

- A. Ethical distinctions are abolished outright, since the absolute alone is finally real
- B. Ethical life remains fully binding at the empirical level while losing its claim to ultimacy
- C. Ethical life is itself ultimate, since purification is necessary for liberating knowledge to dawn
- D. Ethical distinctions belong to the apparent level of reality along with dream objects and illusions

Answer: B. Ethical life remains fully binding at the empirical level while losing its claim to ultimacy

- **A:** Abolition is not entailed; the thesis reclassifies rather than cancels, which is why purification remains indispensable in practice.
- **B:** Correct - duty, merit, sin and karmic causality are valid within worldly existence and are denied only final status, which is exactly the point at which critics press the charge of downgrading.
- **C:** Necessity as a preparation does not confer ultimacy; action purifies but is not the direct remover of ignorance.
- **D:** The apparent level covers private cancellations within experience, whereas ethical life belongs to the public empirical order.

Examiner trap 23: Answers oscillate between "ethics is destroyed" and "ethics is ultimate," when the doctrine's actual position is binding-but-not-final, and the criticism is precisely about that middle status.

MCQ 24. The crypto-Buddhist charge

What is the most defensible assessment of the charge that Advaita is crypto-Buddhism?

A. It fails as an identification, but the shared denial of ultimate world-reality remains a real pressure B. It succeeds completely, since both systems deny the reality of the world in exactly the same sense C. It is wholly irrelevant, since Advaita and Buddhism share no doctrine or consequence at any level D. It fails, because Advaita affirms the independent reality of the world exactly as Nyāya realism does

Answer: A. It fails as an identification, but the shared denial of ultimate world-reality remains a real pressure

- **A:** Correct - a shared consequence does not entail a shared premise, so the charge cannot establish identity, yet the convergence on world-negation is a genuine pressure-point rather than nothing.
- **B:** The senses differ: emptiness is standardly presented as absence of own-being, whereas the absolute is a positive ground that is never sublated.
- **C:** Denying any shared feature ignores the convergence that generated the charge and makes the reply look evasive.
- **D:** Advaita denies the world independent ultimate reality, which is exactly what the Nyāya realist affirms, so the two positions are not the same.

Examiner trap 24: The charge is either accepted outright or dismissed outright, whereas the mark-earning answer refutes the identification and concedes the pressure.

REMEDIAL DRILLS

MCQ 25. Dependently real is not wholly non-existent

Which statement follows from the distinction between the dependently real and the wholly non-existent?

A. Both are equally cancelled by liberating knowledge, so the distinction has no real work to do B. The wholly non-existent appears vividly but briefly, whereas the dependently real never appears C. Both are alike products of ignorance, and the difference between them is only one of duration D. The dependently real appears and is later sublated; the wholly non-existent never appears

Answer: D. The dependently real appears and is later sublated; the wholly non-existent never appears

- **A:** Only the dependently real is cancelled, since cancellation presupposes a prior appearance that the wholly non-existent never had.
- **B:** This reverses the two: the hare's horn is the standard example of what never appears, and the world is what appears and functions.
- **C:** Duration is not the criterion; presentability is, and the wholly non-existent fails it absolutely rather than briefly.
- **D:** Correct - appearance followed by sublation defines the middle grade, and never being presented defines the outer one, which is why the world is not a hare's horn.

Examiner trap 25: The sentence "the world is unreal" is written once in the introduction and silently governs the rest of the answer, converting a graded ontology into nihilism.

MCQ 26. Qualitylessness is not blankness

Which formulation of the qualityless absolute is correct?

A. It is free of limiting and objectifiable attributes, while being-consciousness-bliss expresses its essence B. It is devoid of all nature whatsoever, so that nothing can be said of it either truly or falsely at all C. It possesses infinite auspicious qualities but is called qualityless because those qualities stay hidden D. It is qualityless at one level and qualified at another level, both of those levels being equally ultimate

Answer: A. It is free of limiting and objectifiable attributes, while being-consciousness-bliss expresses its essence

- **A:** Correct - the negation targets predicates that would make the absolute one item among knowable items, and the essence is affirmed rather than removed.
- **B:** Total absence of nature is the caricature that Rāmānuja attacks, and conceding it hands the critic the argument at the outset.
- **C:** Hidden qualities is a Viśiṣṭādvaita-flavoured description that misstates both schools, since Rāmānuja's qualities are manifest and Advaita's essence is not a set of qualities.
- **D:** The two levels are not equally ultimate; the qualified Lord belongs to the empirical order and is sublated in the absolute.

Examiner trap 26: A single clause such as "Brahman has no nature at all" undoes an otherwise accurate answer, because every later paragraph then defends an indefensible position.

MCQ 27. Inseparable dependence is not identity

Which pair of claims correctly separates Rāmānuja's position from that of Advaita Vedānta?

A. Rāmānuja holds that the modes are numerically identical with the absolute; Advaita holds that they are appearances B. Rāmānuja holds that modes are real and inseparable but not identical; Advaita holds that plurality lacks ultimacy C. Rāmānuja holds that the modes are independent substances; Advaita holds that they are merely dependent substances D. Rāmānuja holds that the modes are sublated in liberation; Advaita holds that they survive the liberating knowledge

Answer: B. Rāmānuja holds that modes are real and inseparable but not identical; Advaita holds that plurality lacks ultimacy

- **A:** Numerical identity is exactly the reading Rāmānuja rejects, and attributing it to him erases the middle position his system exists to occupy.
- **B:** Correct - real distinctness within inseparable dependence on one substantive whole is his thesis, and denial of ultimate plurality is Advaita's.
- **C:** Independence would make the modes second absolutes, which the doctrine of inseparable existence explicitly forbids.
- **D:** This inverts both schools: Advaita sublates plurality in liberating knowledge, while Rāmānuja's modes remain real in the liberated state.

Examiner trap 27: Because the school is called qualified non-dualism, candidates hear "non-dualism" and describe modes as ultimately one with God, which is the very identity-claim the qualification denies.

MCQ 28. Naming the two powers correctly

Which statement about the two powers of indescribable illusion is correct?

- A. Concealment projects the world of names and forms, while projection hides the absolute's true nature B. Concealment and projection are alternative names for a single undivided function of ignorance C. Concealment belongs to ignorance alone, while projection is exercised by the absolute itself D. Concealment hides the absolute's nature; projection throws up the world of names and forms

Answer: D. Concealment hides the absolute's nature; projection throws up the world of names and forms

- **A:** The two functions are exchanged, which also breaks the parallel with the two components of superimposition.
- **B:** They are distinguished precisely because covering and fabricating are different operations, and a single function could not do both.
- **C:** Projection is not a power of the absolute; both powers belong to illusion or ignorance as a dependent principle.
- **D:** Correct - the covering power explains non-recognition and the projecting power explains positive appearance, and both reappear as the two components of superimposition.

Examiner trap 28: The two powers are named in the right order but described in the wrong one, which usually happens because the answer is recalled as a phrase rather than as two distinct explanatory jobs.

MCQ 29. Liberation while living

Which statement about liberation while living is correct?

- A. It is accepted by all three principal Vedānta schools as the very highest form of liberation B. It is central to Advaita, and is not accepted in that strict sense by Viśiṣṭādvaita or Dvaita C. It is rejected by Advaita, which requires the fall of the body before liberation can occur D. It is accepted by Dvaita, because gradation among liberated souls begins during embodiment

Answer: B. It is central to Advaita, and is not accepted in that strict sense by Viśiṣṭādvaita or Dvaita

- **A:** For Rāmānuja embodiment remains a condition of bondage, so a liberation compatible with embodiment cannot be the highest state.
- **B:** Correct - once ignorance is destroyed the body continues by commenced karma, whereas the realist theisms treat liberation as incompatible with continued embodiment in that sense.
- **C:** Advaita affirms it, and the disembodied state that follows adds no new liberation to what knowledge has already accomplished.
- **D:** Gradation concerns the ranks of liberated souls after release and does not license liberation during embodiment.

Examiner trap 29: Candidates transfer liberation while living to every Vedānta school because all three speak of knowledge, and the distinctive Advaita claim is then wasted.

MCQ 30. Reading the printed 2018 demand

The 2018 paper asks how Rāmānuja refutes the doctrine of illusion and why illusion is "needed" by both Rāmānuja and Śaṅkara. What is the correct approach?

A. Argue that Rāmānuja secretly accepts an indescribable cosmic illusion under a different name B. Decline to answer the second sentence, on the ground that it is philosophically unusual C. Flag the anomaly, state that Rāmānuja rejects Advaitic illusion, and compare explanations D. Treat the second sentence as evidence that Śaṅkara borrowed the doctrine from Rāmānuja

Answer: C. Flag the anomaly, state that Rāmānuja rejects Advaitic illusion, and compare explanations

- **A:** Manufacturing a hidden acceptance contradicts the seven objections and invents doctrine to fit an unusual stem.
- **B:** Refusing a printed part of the question forfeits its marks; the demand must be engaged, not avoided.
- **C:** Correct - the honest route names the anomaly, states the refutation, and answers the comparative demand through inseparable dependence as Rāmānuja's alternative explanation of plurality.
- **D:** The chronology is inverted and no such borrowing is claimed by any source, so the option adds a fabricated historical claim to a doctrinal error.

Examiner trap 30: Faced with an odd stem, candidates either rationalise it into a false doctrine or ignore it; the disciplined response is to flag, correct and then answer the recoverable demand.

MCQ 31. Distinguishing a summary verse from a great sentence

Which statement about the verse "the absolute is real, the world is dependent appearance, the individual self is none other than the absolute" is correct?

A. It is a traditional Advaita summary rather than a standard Upaniṣadic great sentence B. It is the fifth great sentence, drawn from the same corpus as "that thou art" itself C. It is a compact formulation of Rāmānuja's position on the world and the individual self D. It is a Dvaita verse used to summarise the doctrine of the fivefold real differences

Answer: A. It is a traditional Advaita summary rather than a standard Upaniṣadic great sentence

- **A:** Correct - it compresses the Advaita position and is used in the printed 2022 question, but the four standard great sentences are the identity statements drawn from the Upaniṣads themselves.
- **B:** There is no fifth member of the standard list, and treating a doctrinal summary as revelation misstates the textual status of the quotation.
- **C:** Rāmānuja denies that the world is dependent appearance and denies non-difference of the self from the absolute, so the verse states the position he opposes.
- **D:** The verse asserts identity, which is the exact opposite of the fivefold difference doctrine.

Examiner trap 31: The verse is quoted in the answer as scripture, which converts a strong textual discrimination into an avoidable attribution error.

MCQ 32. Attribution and ownership discipline

Which statement is correct about attribution and question-ownership within this syllabus item?

- A. The undivided-form mental mode is a verbatim formula of Śaṅkara, used in his own commentary on the aphorisms
- B. The reflection model is associated with Vācaspati Miśra, while the limitation model belongs to Padmapāda
- C. The 2018 question on the Advaita reaction to real transformation is primary-owned by Sāṃkhya
- D. The unique differentiator in Dvaita is an undisputed doctrine with a single standard formulation

Answer: C. The 2018 question on the Advaita reaction to real transformation is primary-owned by Sāṃkhya

- **A:** It is a later systematic explanation of how knowledge removes error and should not be presented as Śaṅkara's own wording.
- **B:** The associations are reversed; delimitation is linked to Vācaspati Miśra and reflection to Padmapāda and the Vivaraṇa line.
- **C:** Correct - the routing ledger assigns that part to Sāṃkhya, so it is supporting material for Vedānta rather than one of the twenty owned questions.
- **D:** Expositions of the unique differentiator vary, and the honest answer reports it with that caution rather than as settled doctrine.

Examiner trap 32: Ownership and attribution are treated as bookkeeping rather than as content, so answers claim borrowed questions and quote later formulations as primary-source wording.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Ownership. Vedānta owns twenty primary parts in the 2018-2025 Paper I corpus - three in 2018, one in 2019, three in 2020, three in 2021, three in 2022, three in 2023, one in 2024 and three in 2025 - second only to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika. All twenty are reproduced and solved below. Two further parts, the 2018 Sāṃkhya question on the Advaita reaction to real transformation and the 2018 Mīmāṃsā question on self-luminosity and intrinsic validity, are supporting routes only and are primary-owned elsewhere.

Status of the model answers. UPSC Mains publishes no official answer key or model answer. Every solution below is independent learner practice written to the stated word band and directive, and it is never presented as an official key.

Declared answer bands. 10 marks: 150-200 words. 15 marks: 250-300 words. 20 marks: 340-400 words. Every solved answer states its exact word count.

VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - 20 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018, Question 5(c), 10 marks

Printed question. What is the difference between the indescribability (Anirvacanīyatā) of Brahman and the indescribability (Anirvacanīyatā) of Māyā in the Advaita Vedānta system? Discuss.

Directive read. "Difference" is the operative word. A paragraph on each term without a stated contrast scores badly; the answer must isolate the sense in which each is called indescribable.

Model answer (190 words).

Advaita applies one word, indescribable (**anirvacanīya**), to two items for opposite reasons, and the difference decides whether the system is coherent.

Ultimate reality (**brahman**) is indescribable because it is non-dual and non-objectifiable, and therefore exceeds limiting subject-predicate description. Any determinate predicate would make it one knowable item among others, which contradicts its status as the ground of all knowing. Its essence - being-consciousness-bliss (**sat-cit-ānanda**) - is affirmed, not withheld, and it is never sublated (**trikālābādhita**). Its indescribability is thus a *surplus*: too real to be predicated.

Indescribable illusion (**māyā**) is indescribable because it cannot be classified as being (**sat**), since knowledge sublates its products, nor as non-being (**asat**), since it is experienced and sheer non-being never appears. Its indescribability is an *indeterminacy*: it falls between the two ultimate ontological heads rather than beyond them.

The absolute is the unsublated reality because of which description and experience are possible; illusion is a dependent, sublatale explanatory principle. Critically, realist schools concede the first transcendence far more readily than the alleged third ontological status of the second.

Why this earns marks. It names the shared term, separates surplus from indeterminacy with the technical vocabulary, supplies the sublation criterion that grounds the distinction, and closes with a critical asymmetry instead of a summary.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018, Question 7(a), 20 marks

Printed question. Give a comparative exposition of the concept of Mokṣa as found in the systems of Viśiṣṭādvaita, Dvaita, Śuddhādvaita and Acintyabhedābheda.

Directive read. Four named systems, comparative exposition. Advaita is not asked and should not occupy the answer. The comparison must be structured, not four sequential summaries.

Model answer (375 words).

All four systems are theistic and treat grace as indispensable, so a comparison that stops at "devotion and grace" explains nothing. What separates them is what a soul *is*, from which four different liberations follow.

Qualified non-dualism (Viśiṣṭādvaita). The self is a real, atomic, conscious mode (**prakāra**) inseparably dependent on ultimate reality, related as body to indwelling soul. Liberation is the recovery of its unobstructed nature: karmic obstruction ends, attributive consciousness (**dharma-bhūta-jñāna**) becomes unrestricted, and the self enjoys knowledge and bliss in eternal communion and service without numerical identity. Devotion (**bhakti**) matured from disinterested action, and self-surrender (**prapatti**) as an inclusive route, dispose the soul toward liberating grace (**prasāda**). Liberation while living is not accepted in the strict Advaita sense, since embodiment remains a condition of bondage.

Dualism (Dvaita). The self is a real dependent substance eternally different from God, not God's body. Liberation is eternal blissful service of Viṣṇu, attained through right knowledge of his supremacy, devotion and grace. Difference is never abolished, and Madhva adds gradation (**tāratamya**): liberated souls do not enjoy identical rank or bliss. Standard sources further classify some bound souls as eternal transmigrators or darkness-eligible - doctrinally supportable, but the sharpest normative difficulty in the system.

Pure non-dualism (Śuddhādvaita). Souls and world are real manifestations of Kṛṣṇa through unchanged real manifestation (**avikṛta-pariṇāma**), neither apparent transformation nor a modification that alters the absolute. Liberation is participation in Kṛṣṇa's bliss and loving service on the path of grace (**puṣṭi-mārga**); the world is not sublated and individuality is not lost.

Inconceivable difference-non-difference (Acintyabhedābheda). Souls and world are really non-different as dependent divine powers and really different as distinct manifestations; "inconceivable" marks the limits of finite reduction, not a licence for contradiction. Loving devotion (**prema-bhakti**) is the sole direct path, culminating in eternal loving relation.

Verdict. Ranked by how much individuality survives, all four preserve it, but for different reasons: inseparable qualification, eternal difference, unchanged manifestation, and inconceivable simultaneity. The decisive comparative line is that Viśiṣṭādvaita secures relation by making the soul internal to God, Dvaita by keeping it external, Śuddhādvaita by making it a real manifestation, and the Caitanya tradition by refusing the choice.

Why this earns marks. It refuses the flattening the question invites, organises by the soul-account rather than by school-summary, uses each system's own technical term, notes the contested element in Dvaita, and closes with a single comparative formula.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2018, Question 7(c), 15 marks

Printed question. How does Rāmānuja refute the doctrine of Māyā as propounded by Śaṅkara? Why is Māyā needed by both Rāmānuja and Śaṅkara to establish their doctrines? Discuss.

Directive read. The first sentence is standard. The second is philosophically unusual as printed, since Rāmānuja rejects Advaitic illusion; it must be flagged and then answered as a demand about how each system explains plurality.

Model answer (294 words).

Rāmānuja's refutation is the sevenfold charge of incoherence (**sapta-anupapatti**). Ignorance can have no tenable locus (**āśraya**): placed in the absolute it destroys pure consciousness, placed in the individual it presupposes what it explains, yielding mutual dependence (**anyonyāśraya**). It cannot conceal a self-luminous (**svayaṃ-prakāśa**) reality without destroying its nature. Its own nature is incoherent if it is neither real nor unreal, and "indescribable" names a third box rather than establishing one. No means of valid knowledge delivers a positive ignorance: "I do not know" reports an absence, not an entity. Neither the remover nor the cessation of ignorance can be coherently specified.

Advaita replies at each point - the Vivaraṇa and Bhāmatī locations of ignorance, the cloud that obstructs the viewer rather than the sun, grades measured by sublation (**bādhā**), witness-perception and postulation, the undivided-form mental mode, and cessation as the absolute simply remaining. The residue is real: the locus and the proof are the two places where Advaita cannot answer without presupposing its own standpoint.

The printed second demand is unusual, because Rāmānuja does not accept illusion; the question is best read as asking what each system must posit to explain plurality. Śaṅkara needs a dependent, sublatale, indescribable power to let a changeless absolute appear as many while remaining unmodified. Rāmānuja needs no such power because he supplies inseparable dependence (**apṛthaksiddhi**): conscious selves and non-conscious matter are real modes inseparably qualifying one substantive whole, related as body to indwelling soul, with error explained by apprehension of the real (**satkhyāti**).

Thus both systems must explain plurality, and both pay a price - Śaṅkara an extra indefinable principle, Rāmānuja a pressure on divine simplicity - but only one of them posits illusion.

Why this earns marks. It compresses seven objections without listing them mechanically, supplies the Advaita replies and the honest residue, flags the printed anomaly instead of rationalising it, and converts the odd second demand into a genuine comparison of explanatory strategies.

Printed question. Explain the logical consequences of the metaphysical absolutism of Advaitism.

Directive read. "Logical consequences" means derivation. A restatement of Advaita's doctrines in sequence does not answer it; each consequence must be shown to follow from the single thesis.

Model answer (366 words).

Advaitic absolutism is the thesis that ultimate reality alone is finally real (**pāramārthika**), everything else being empirically real (**vyāvahārika**) and sublatale. Five consequences follow, and one tension.

First, the world is reduced to appearance. If nothing besides the absolute is independently real, the world cannot be so; it becomes dependently real (**mithyā**) - a sublatale appearance on a real substrate, as the snake is on the rope. It is not wholly non-existent (**tuccha**), because what never appears cannot be cancelled.

Second, individuality and agency become provisional. The individual as finite doer-enjoyer belongs to ignorance-conditioned existence. Moral agency is affirmed empirically and denied ultimacy.

Third, ethics and karma become empirical. Duty, merit, sin and karmic causality remain valid within worldly existence but do not belong to the final truth. This yields flexibility and invites the charge that ethics is downgraded.

Fourth, devotion becomes preparatory. The Lord (**īśvara**) is the absolute conditioned by illusion, fully real at the empirical level. If so, worship is pedagogically indispensable but not final - which is precisely Rāmānuja's objection that scriptural theism is thereby made provisional.

Fifth, the means of valid knowledge are empirically valid only. All six presuppose the triad knower-means-known (**pramātṛ-pramāṇa-prameya**), hence duality. On realisation the whole apparatus is transcended, including scripture.

The self-referential tension. Advaita therefore uses reasoning and revelation to establish a truth that finally relativises reasoning and revelation. Is this self-defeat? The tradition's answer is the ladder-model: revelation removes ignorance and lapses with it, like the clearing-nut (**kataka**) that settles with the mud, or the stick consumed in the pyre it stirs. Self-cancellation is orderly, not arbitrary, because it coincides with the removal of the ignorance that made the instrument necessary.

Assessment. The defensible reply is that nothing is abolished, only reclassified: the world remains public and law-governed, ethics binding, devotion effective. What is withdrawn is the claim to finality. Whether obligation survives being classified as non-ultimate is exactly what critics deny. Advaita's absolutism purchases metaphysical purity at the cost of reclassifying ordinary life as lower truth - the highest wisdom to its admirers, ontological austerity bought by practical instability to its critics.

Why this earns marks. It derives rather than lists, keeps the dependently-real qualification attached to consequence one, reaches the self-referential tension that the twenty-mark allocation demands, and closes with a graded verdict that names both readings.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020, Question 5(d), 10 marks

Printed question. Point out the significance of the five-fold differences in the Dualistic School of Vedānta.

Directive read. "Significance," not "enumerate." All five must be named, but the marks lie in what follows from them.

Model answer (179 words).

Madhva's fivefold difference (**pañcavidhabheda**) asserts five real and eternal differences: soul-God (**jīva-īśvara-bheda**), soul-soul (**jīva-jīva-bheda**), soul-matter (**jīva-jaḍa-bheda**), God-matter (**īśvara-jaḍa-bheda**) and matter-matter (**jaḍa-jaḍa-bheda**). These are not practical distinctions produced by ignorance; they are metaphysically ultimate.

Their significance is fourfold. First, they reject Advaita's identity directly, since difference cannot be sublated if it is constitutive of reality. Second, they equally reject Rāmānuja's attempt to retain unity through qualified inseparability, so Dvaita is not merely anti-Advaita. Third, the two internal differences do the distinctive work: soul-soul difference makes hierarchy among souls possible and underwrites gradation (**tāratamya**) in liberation, while matter-matter difference makes the plural world ontologically robust. Fourth, since the soul remains eternally different from God, devotion is never transcended; it is the permanent form of the relation, not a means to be discarded.

Difference does not threaten divine supremacy, because supremacy is defined by independence (**svatantra**) against universal dependence (**paratantra**). The cost is real: permanent hierarchy among souls remains the system's sharpest normative difficulty.

Why this earns marks. It names all five in Sanskrit, identifies the two members that carry the distinctive consequences, shows the doctrine as doubly polemical, and ends with a cost rather than a restatement.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2020, Question 5(e), 10 marks

Printed question. Discuss the nature and types of matter according to Nimbārka.

Directive read. Two demands - nature and types. Both must appear, and the classification must be stated with the caution that expositions vary.

Model answer (182 words).

In Nimbārka's dualistic non-dualism (**dvaitādvaita**), non-conscious reality (**acit**) is real, dependent and transformable. Its nature is fixed by the school's governing relation: matter differs from ultimate reality because it is limited, and is non-different because it has no independent existence. It is therefore neither an Advaitic illusion nor a second absolute; it is related to ultimate reality as a power or attribute to its possessor, and creation is a real transformation of the absolute's dependent powers.

The standard classification gives three types: ordinary primordial matter (**prākṛta**), that is material nature and its products; non-prakritic substance (**apṛākṛta**), associated with the divine realm or body; and time (**kāla**). Terminology and the placement of time vary across expositions, so an answer should state the classification it adopts rather than multiply subtypes.

Philosophically this secures both halves of the school's name. Because matter is real, the world is not cancelled by liberating knowledge; because it is dependent, its reality does not compete with God's. Liberation therefore preserves individuality while knowledge is enabled by devotion and grace.

Why this earns marks. It answers nature and types separately, gives the threefold classification with its correct technical terms, records the variation honestly, and links the ontology back to the school's characteristic relation and soteriology.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2020, Question 8(c), 15 marks

Printed question. Discuss the nature and relationship of Jīva and Jīva-sākṣī according to non-dualism.

Directive read. Two terms and one relation. The relation is the graded element: the answer must say why the witness is not simply a second self standing beside the individual.

Model answer (293 words).

In non-dualism the individual self (**jīva**) is ultimate reality appearing finite: consciousness delimited or reflected in ignorance (**avidyā**) together with the internal organ, and therefore appearing as a doer, enjoyer and transmigrator. Advaita explains this appearance by three models - limitation (**avaccheda-vāda**, associated with Vācaspati Miśra, using pot-space), reflection (**pratibimba-vāda**, associated with Padmapāda and the Vivaraṇa line, using the mirrored face), and semblance (**ābhāsa-vāda**) - which stress plurality, vividness and ontological thinness respectively while converging on one conclusion: individuality lacks ultimate reality.

The witness (**sākṣī**) is pure witnessing consciousness. It illumines every mental state without being altered by any: pleasure, pain, doubt, memory and desire are witnessed, not essential to it. It is self-luminous (**svayaṃ-prakāśa**) and non-objectifiable, and it is not a passive blank but the condition of all experience. The classical support is the survey of waking (**jāgrat**), dream (**svapna**) and deep sleep (**suṣupti**): the later report "I slept peacefully; I knew nothing" presupposes continuity through a state without object-cognition. The fourth standpoint (**turiya**) is not a further episode but the consciousness underlying all three.

Their relationship is not that of two selves. The witness is the individual's own essential consciousness considered apart from adjuncts; the individual is that same consciousness considered along with them. The apparent relation is therefore due to limiting adjuncts (**upādhi**), not to a real distinction of substances. In the hierarchy of the 2022 question, the witness stands closest to the ultimate standpoint, the individual belongs to empirical bondage.

Critically, the deep-sleep argument establishes an enduring witness more securely than it establishes non-dual identity; Rāmānuja and Nyāya accept the first and reject the second.

Why this earns marks. It defines both terms precisely, names the three explanatory models with their expositors and images, states the relation as adjunct-conditioned rather than substantial, and qualifies the school's own supporting argument.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2021, Question 7(a), 20 marks

Printed question. How do the advocates of anirvacanīya-khyāti refute the position of the Naiyāyikas and establish the position of Advaitins regarding the problem of error? Critically discuss.

Directive read. Two verbs - refute and establish - plus "critically." The answer needs a refutation, a positive construction, and a residual assessment.

Model answer (392 words).

The problem of error asks what is presented when a shell is seen as silver. Nyāya answers with apprehension otherwise (**anyathā-khyāti**): the silver is real silver, known elsewhere, wrongly connected with this locus through a defective sense-relation and revived memory. Nothing unreal is ever presented.

The refutation. Advaita objects that this misdescribes the correction. Sublation takes the form "this is a shell" and cancels the silver *at that very locus*; it does not relocate it. Had the presented object been a real silver merely misconnected, correction would dissolve a relation, not annihilate the object's apparent objecthood so radically. Further, the illusory silver is practically effective - one reaches for it - which a bare memory-image ought not to be. Hence the presented silver cannot simply be real silver misplaced in cognition.

The construction. Advaita then argues by elimination within an exhaustive trichotomy. If the silver were being (**sat**), it would be never sublated (**trikālābādhita**) and would survive correct knowledge; it does not. If it were non-being (**asat**), like a hare's horn, it could never have appeared; but it did. Buddhist apprehension of the non-existent (**asat-khyāti**) fails for that reason. Therefore it is indescribable (**anirvacanīya**): experienced yet sublated. This presupposes that sublation (**bādha**) grades reality, and that ignorance is positive in form (**bhāva-rūpa**), since a mere absence could not both conceal and project.

Why it matters. The theory is the epistemological miniature of the metaphysics: what shell-silver is to shell, the world is to ultimate reality. Superimposition (**adhyāsa**) supplies the process, the error-theory the status of its product.

Critical assessment. Three limits must be stated. First, the refutation establishes an anomaly for Nyāya rather than a proof of the third grade; the Naiyāyika can reply that cancellation removes only the wrong connection. Second, the positive argument is valid only if sublatability is accepted as an ontological criterion - precisely what Rāmānuja and Madhva deny. Third, Rāmānuja offers a rival that keeps realism: apprehension of the real (**satkhyāti**), with elemental intermixture supplying a genuine silver-element in the shell.

The verdict is therefore graded. Within a system that already grades reality by sublation, the theory is elegant and unifying; against a realist who refuses that criterion, it establishes a puzzle rather than a proof.

Why this earns marks. It separates refutation from construction as the question does, names the rival theories with their technical terms, supplies the presuppositions that make the elimination work, and delivers a graded verdict rather than an endorsement.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2021, Question 8(b), 15 marks

Printed question. Compare and contrast the views of Śaṅkara and Rāmānuja regarding the status of the world.

Directive read. "Compare and contrast" requires both the shared ground and the divergence, and rewards a structured comparison over two separate expositions.

Model answer (281 words).

Both thinkers agree on three things: the world depends entirely on ultimate reality; there is no second independent principle; and scripture is the final authority for what the world is. They diverge on what dependence permits.

For Śaṅkara the world is an apparent transformation (**vivarta**). Ultimate reality does not really change; the world is a sublatale appearance on a real substrate, as the snake is on the rope. It is therefore dependently real (**mithyā**) - denied absolute reality but retaining public, law-governed empirical validity - and emphatically not wholly non-existent (**tuccha**). The three levels of reality make this intelligible: the absolute alone is ultimate, the world and the Lord are empirical, dream and shell-silver are apparent.

For Rāmānuja the world is real. It is the non-conscious (**acit**) dimension of ultimate reality's body, related by inseparable dependence (**apṛthaksiddhi**). Creation is a real manifestation in which the subtle cause-state of the non-conscious mode becomes the gross effect-state, while God's essential auspicious nature is unaltered. Because effects are real, the world is a meaningful field of duty, devotion and divine manifestation.

The contrast can be tabulated: reality of the world - dependent appearance against real manifestation; change in the absolute - denied against accepted in a qualified sense through modes; soteriology - the world sublated in knowledge against the world meaningful in devotion; the God-world relation - empirical against an intrinsic body-soul relation.

The evaluative line is that each protects what the other qualifies: Śaṅkara protects absoluteness by reducing world-status, Rāmānuja protects world-status by qualifying absoluteness. Vallabha's unchanged real manifestation shows the fork is not exhaustive, but the two positions remain the decisive alternatives.

Why this earns marks. It states shared ground before divergence, uses each school's own causal vocabulary, converts the contrast into four comparable issues, and closes with a symmetrical evaluative line plus one line showing awareness of a third option.

Printed question. Explain the status of jīva and jagat in the philosophy of Madhvācārya.

Directive read. Two terms, one philosopher. "Status" means ontological standing, so the answer must state what kind of reality each has and what follows.

Model answer (284 words).

Madhva's ontology is governed by one division: only God is independent (**svatantra**); everything else is dependent (**paratantra**). Both the individual self and the world fall on the dependent side, and both are fully real.

The individual self (jīva). It is a real, distinct, dependent substance - never reducible to God, never a mere mode of God, and never illusory. Difference from God is fundamental rather than produced by ignorance, so the self never becomes God even in liberation. Difference among selves is equally real. The standard taxonomy distinguishes the eternally free (**nitya**), the liberated (**mukta**) and the bound (**baddha**); bound souls are further described as liberation-eligible (**mukti-yogya**), eternal transmigrators (**nitya-saṃsārin**) and darkness-eligible (**tamo-yogya**). This gradation is doctrinally Madhva's own, but it is the most contested element of his system and should be evaluated, not merely reported.

The world (jagat). It is real and eternally distinct from God. Its dependence does not cancel its distinctness. God is its efficient cause (**nimitta-kāraṇa**) and governor, while dependent primordial matter (**prakṛti**) is the real material cause - so, unlike Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita, Madhva does not make God the material cause. Matter is not absorbed into identity by knowledge.

What follows. Both statuses feed directly into fivefold difference (**pañcavidhabheda**): soul-God, soul-soul, soul-matter, God-matter and matter-matter differences are real and eternal. Because difference is constitutive, devotion is never transcended; liberation is eternal blissful service with gradation (**tāratamya**) rather than identity.

This yields the strongest realist posture in Vedānta. Its cost is that non-dual Upaniṣadic sentences become harder to interpret and permanent hierarchy among souls requires defence.

Why this earns marks. It anchors both terms in the independence-dependence formula, states the causal division that distinguishes Madhva from the other two schools, connects both to the fivefold difference, and ends with strength and cost together.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2022, Question 5(e), 10 marks

Printed question. Do you agree with the view that 'Vivartavāda is the logical development of Pariṇāmavāda'? Give reasons in support of your answer.

Directive read. "Do you agree?" asks for a reasoned position, not an opinion. The word "development" makes an unqualified yes or no wrong; the answer must grade the agreement.

Model answer (198 words).

I agree only partially, and the qualification carries the argument.

The case for agreement is structural. Sāṃkhya's real transformation (**pariṇāma-vāda**) holds that the effect pre-exists in and is a genuine modification of its cause. Advaita accepts the underlying demand - the effect must depend on its cause and cannot come from nothing - but applies it to an absolute that admits no modification. If the cause is changeless, the effect cannot be a real transformation of it; therefore transformation must be only apparent (**vivarta**). In that sense apparent transformation preserves cause-dependence while protecting changelessness, and looks like the logic of real transformation carried to its limit.

The case against is ontological. Real transformation and apparent transformation assign contrary grades of reality to the effect: milk really becomes curd, whereas the rope never becomes the snake. What real transformation most insists on - genuine change in the cause - is precisely what apparent transformation abandons. A doctrine that denies the core commitment of another is a rejection, not a completion.

The graded verdict follows: agreement is structural, disagreement is ontological. Apparent transformation develops the search for a dependent effect and abandons real transformation's central claim.

Why this earns marks. It takes a position, argues both directions with the standard examples, uses the exact technical terms, and delivers a graded verdict that answers the word "development" rather than the word "transformation."

Solved PYQ 12 - 2022, Question 8(a), 20 marks

Printed question. 'Brahma satyam jagannmithyā, Jīvo Brahmaiva nāparaḥ'. In the light of this statement explain the ontological status of Īśvara, Jīva and Sākṣī as elucidated in Advaita Vedānta.

Directive read. Three terms whose *ontological status* is asked, framed by a quoted verse. The verse must be used as an organising thesis, and its textual status should be identified.

Model answer (398 words).

The quoted line compresses Advaita into three claims: ultimate reality is real, the world is dependent appearance, and the individual self is none other than ultimate reality. It is a traditional Advaita summary rather than one of the four standard Upaniṣadic great sentences, and saying so is itself a mark of textual discipline. Read as a thesis, it fixes the status of all three terms asked.

The Lord (īśvara). The Lord is ultimate reality conditioned by indescribable illusion (**māyā-upahita brahman**), the omniscient, omnipotent creator and moral governor of the empirical world. His status is therefore *fully real at the empirical level* (**vyāvahārika**) and sublated at the ultimate level (**pāramārthika**). Theism in Advaita is thus neither false in a crude sense nor final in the last sense - which is exactly the point at which Rāmānuja objects that devotion is made provisional.

The individual self (jīva). The individual is ultimate reality limited or reflected in ignorance together with the internal organ, appearing as doer, enjoyer and transmigrator. Its status is empirical bondage. Advaita explains the appearance three ways: limitation (**avaccheda-vāda**, pot-space), reflection (**pratibimba-vāda**, the mirrored face) and semblance (**ābhāsa-vāda**), which stress plurality, vividness and ontological thinness while agreeing that individuality lacks ultimate reality. The second clause of the verse is thus literal: the individual is "none other than" the absolute in essence.

The witness (sākṣī). The witness is pure witnessing consciousness - unaffected, immediate, self-luminous (**svayaṃ-prakāśa**) and non-objectifiable. It illumines all mental states without being altered by them, and is supported by the three-state analysis, where the report "I slept peacefully; I knew nothing" presupposes continuity through deep

sleep. Its status is closest to the ultimate standpoint, since it is the individual's own essential consciousness considered apart from adjuncts.

The hierarchy. The three are not three substances but one consciousness under three descriptions: the witness closest to the ultimate standpoint, the individual in empirical bondage, and the Lord in cosmic-ordering empirical reality. The first clause of the verse fixes the world as dependently real (**mithyā**) - sublatale, not wholly non-existent - and the whole scheme is intelligible only through the three levels of reality graded by sublation (**bādhā**).

Critically, the elegance of the hierarchy is purchased by the cost the verse itself concedes: the Lord, and therefore devotion, cannot be final.

Why this earns marks. It uses the quotation as a thesis rather than as decoration, identifies its textual status, gives each term a precise ontological placement, unifies the three under one consciousness, and closes with the cost the doctrine pays.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2022, Question 8(c), 15 marks

Printed question. How does the concept of Liberation (Mokṣa) of Madhvācārya differ from that of Rāmānujācārya? Explain.

Directive read. "Differ" is the whole question. Shared ground must be stated briefly and then left; the body must be organised by points of divergence.

Model answer (272 words).

Both are theists who reject Advaitic identity, hold God, soul and world to be real, and make devotion and grace indispensable. Stating this and stopping is the standard failure; the differences are structural.

God-self relation. For Rāmānuja the self is an inseparable mode (**prakāra**) and body of ultimate reality, related by inseparable dependence (**aprthaksiddhi**) and the body-soul relation (**śarīra-śarīrī-bhāva**). For Madhva the self is a distinct dependent substance and expressly not God's body, since a real self cannot be another's instrument.

Content of liberation. Rāmānuja's liberated self recovers its unobstructed nature and likeness to God, enjoying eternal communion and service without numerical identity. Madhva's liberated self enjoys eternal blissful service in permanent difference.

Knowledge and bliss. For Rāmānuja karmic obstruction ends and attributive consciousness (**dharma-bhūta-jñāna**) becomes unrestricted. For Madhva the degree of knowledge and bliss follows a real hierarchy.

Equality of the liberated. This is the sharpest difference. Rāmānuja's liberated souls are alike in essential type, with no intrinsic gradation. Madhva holds gradation (**tāratamya**): released souls do not enjoy identical rank or bliss, and standard sources further classify some bound souls as eternal transmigrators or darkness-eligible.

Causal background. Rāmānuja makes ultimate reality both efficient and material cause through real modes; Madhva makes God the efficient cause with dependent primordial matter as the material cause.

The conclusion should not be "both are devotional." Rāmānuja resolves plurality through inseparable qualification, so unity is preserved and difference is internal; Madhva treats qualitative difference and hierarchy as permanent, so unity is only dependence. The cost is correspondingly different: divine simplicity for Rāmānuja, moral universality for Madhva.

Why this earns marks. It disposes of the shared ground in one sentence, organises five explicit points of divergence, names the gradation doctrine that most answers omit, and ends with the structural formula plus each system's cost.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2023, Question 5(c), 10 marks

Printed question. What is Advaitin interpretation of the great sentence (mahāvākya) 'Thou art that' (tat tvam asi)? Briefly discuss.

Directive read. "Briefly discuss" still requires the mechanism. Naming the device without showing what is dropped and what is kept is the standard half-answer.

Model answer (171 words).

Taken literally the sentence is false. The direct meaning (**vāc्यārtha**) of *tat* is the omniscient, remote Lord associated with illusion; the direct meaning of *tvam* is the finite, immediate individual associated with ignorance and limitation. Omniscience and cosmic causality cannot literally be identical with finitude, agency and ignorance.

Advaita therefore reads it through part-abandoning implication (**bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā**), also called abandoning-and-retaining implication (**jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā**). The incompatible portions of both direct meanings are abandoned - lordship, omniscience and cosmic causality on one side; finitude, agency and ignorance on the other - and the common implied meaning (**lakṣyārtha**), pure consciousness, is retained.

The canonical parallel is *so'yaṃ devadattaḥ*, "this is that Devadatta," where "then and there" and "now and here" are dropped and the identical person is retained. The sentence thus teaches identity of essence, not sameness of empirical condition.

Viśiṣṭādvaita and Dvaita reject this reading, taking the sentence to indicate dependence or special relation. One sentence therefore becomes the battleground for the whole architecture of Vedānta.

Why this earns marks. It states the problem before the solution, names the device in both forms, specifies precisely what is abandoned and retained, uses the canonical parallel as argument, and adds the rival reading in one line.

Solved PYQ 15 - 2023, Question 6(a), 20 marks

Printed question. Discuss Rāmānuja's criticism of Śaṅkara's conception of Brahman and Īśvara (God).

Directive read. Two targets - the absolute and the Lord. An answer that criticises only the qualityless absolute answers half the question.

Model answer (387 words).

Rāmānuja's critique has two halves, matching the two terms named, and both rest on one epistemological thesis: *sarvaṃ vijñānaṃ saviśeṣaṃ* - all cognition is of the qualified.

Against the qualityless absolute. Śaṅkara holds that ultimate reality is qualityless (**nirguṇa**), free of limiting, relational and objectifiable attributes, with being-consciousness-bliss as its essence and all determinate qualities assigned to the Lord at the empirical level. Rāmānuja objects that an entity without attributes cannot be known at all. If utterly indeterminate, it cannot be the referent of scriptural description, since scripture describes by predicates. If it has no internal intelligibility, it cannot ground a richly qualified world. Scriptural passages that negate defects do not negate all qualities; they deny limiting or undesirable predicates while affirming perfection. Rāmānuja does not deny indeterminate perception (**nirvikalpaka**) - he redefines it as the first cognition of an individual already grasped with its configuration - but he denies cognition of a wholly qualifierless (**nirviśeṣa**) object. Hence Śaṅkara's absolute becomes either unknowable emptiness or an abstraction too thin to ground religion, devotion, causality or ethics. Positively, ultimate reality is qualified by infinite auspicious qualities (**ananta-kalyāṇa-guṇa-viśiṣṭa**), and qualification is what makes absoluteness intelligible rather than what limits it.

Against the Lord's status. In Advaita the Lord is ultimate reality conditioned by illusion (**māyā-upahita brahman**), real at the empirical level and sublated at the ultimate. Rāmānuja argues that this hollows out religion: devotion becomes merely preparatory, scriptural descriptions of God become lower truth rather than final truth, and religious life is structurally subordinated to non-personal absolutism. For him the Lord simply *is* ultimate reality, the supreme personal Viṣṇu-Nārāyaṇa, with no level above him; he is immanent because selves and world are his body, and transcendent because he exceeds them.

Advaita's reply. The absolute is not known as an object with predicates; it is self-revealed as the ground of all knowing, so unknowability follows only if all knowing is objectifying. Negation of limiting predicates is not negation of

nature.

Verdict. The dispute turns on a prior question: whether cognition can reach a non-objective reality. Granting Rāmānuja's epistemological premise makes Śaṅkara's absolute unknowable; granting Śaṅkara's self-luminosity makes Rāmānuja's demand for predicates question-begging. Rāmānuja's critique is strongest where religion is concerned and weakest where it presupposes that all knowledge is predicative.

Why this earns marks. It answers both named terms, grounds the critique in Rāmānuja's own epistemological thesis, states his positive alternative, supplies the Advaita reply, and closes by locating the disagreement in a shared prior question.

Solved PYQ 16 - 2023, Question 7(b), 15 marks

Printed question. Liberation is defined by Advaita Vedāntins as 'attainment of that which is already attained'. How does Śaṅkara illustrate this statement? Discuss with your own comments.

Directive read. Three demands: explain the definition, give Śaṅkara's *illustrations*, and add independent comment. The illustrations are not optional decoration here.

Model answer (296 words).

The definition is **prāptasya prāptiḥ**. Liberation produces nothing new because the self is always ultimate reality; bondage is ignorance alone, so release can only be the removal of ignorance by knowledge. If liberation were produced, it would be an effect, and every effect is impermanent - which would make liberation temporary.

How it is illustrated. The teaching relies on the logic of *already-obtained* things wrongly believed absent: the necklace searched for while hanging round one's own neck, and the rope-snake correction in which nothing is created or destroyed when the snake is cancelled and the rope recognised. Superimposition (**adhyāsa**) supplies the mechanism - the self's attributes are transferred to the not-self and the not-self's to the self - so the correction removes a false identification rather than adding a state. Preparation is real but indirect: the fourfold qualification (**sādhana-catustaya**), then hearing, reflection and contemplation (**śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana**). Action (**karma**) and worship (**upāsana**) purify but do not combine with knowledge, which is Śaṅkara's rejection of the knowledge-and-action combination (**jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda**). The corollary is liberation while living (**jīvanmukti**): the body continues by commenced karma (**prārabdha**), like an arrow already released, and disembodied liberation (**videhamukti**) adds nothing new.

Comment. The definition is forced by the diagnosis, not chosen for elegance: if bondage is a mistaken belief, only cognition can be its direct remover. Its strength is that it explains why liberation can be present-tense and why it cannot be lost. Its cost is what Rāmānuja presses - if individuality was never ultimately real, it is unclear who enjoys the freedom, and devotion is reduced to preparation. The doctrine is therefore coherent within its own criterion of reality and contestable precisely at that criterion.

Why this earns marks. It explains the definition, supplies both illustrations with their mechanism, keeps the preparatory apparatus in its correct subordinate place, and delivers genuine independent comment rather than a restatement.

Solved PYQ 17 - 2024, Question 5(e), 10 marks

Printed question. "In Viśiṣṭādvaita philosophy, the relationship between God and the world is parallel to that between an individual self and its body." Critically discuss.

Directive read. "Critically" in a ten-marker means one clear limit, not a survey. The three conditions of bodyhood must be stated before the limit is drawn.

Model answer (191 words).

The statement is accurate as far as it goes. In Rāmānuja's system selves (**cit**) and matter (**acit**) constitute ultimate reality's body (**śarīra**), while ultimate reality is their indwelling soul (**śarīrin**). Bodyhood is defined by three conditions: what is entirely supported by an indwelling self, entirely controlled by it, and existing for its purposes. All three hold of the world with respect to God.

Two clarifications are essential. First, "body" is functional, not physical: it means whatever is supported, controlled and used by an indwelling self, which is why conscious selves can also be called God's body. Second, the relation is inseparable dependence (**apṛthaksiddhi**): the modes are real and distinct but cannot exist or be conceived apart from their substance - stronger than a conceptual relation, weaker than identity.

Critically, the parallel is asymmetric. An ordinary self is affected, limited and pained by its body's defects; God's essential auspicious nature is untouched by the world's imperfections. The analogy therefore holds for support, control and purpose, and fails for vulnerability. Madhva presses this further: a real self cannot be another's instrument at all.

Why this earns marks. It states the three defining conditions, corrects the two predictable misreadings, and answers "critically" with a precise structural limit and a named rival objection rather than generalised praise.

Solved PYQ 18 - 2025, Question 5(d), 10 marks

Printed question. Examine Rāmānuja's seven objections against Māyāvāda of Advaita.

Directive read. "Examine" requires more than enumeration. All seven must appear, but at least one reply and a verdict on relative force are needed within the word band.

Model answer (200 words).

The sevenfold charge of incoherence (**sapta-anupapatti**) attacks the doctrine of ignorance at seven points; names and order vary slightly across expositions.

Locus (āśraya): ignorance can reside neither in the absolute, which it would defile, nor in the individual, which it produces - mutual dependence (**anyonyāśraya**). **Concealment (tirodhāna):** a self-luminous reality cannot be concealed without destroying its nature. **Nature (svarūpa):** something neither real nor unreal has no coherent nature. **Indefinability (anirvacanīyatva):** a third category names the problem instead of solving it. **Means of knowing (pramāṇa):** no instrument establishes a positive ignorance; "I do not know" reports an absence. **Remover (nivartaka):** contentless knowledge cannot remove it, and determinate knowledge lies within it. **Cessation (nivṛtti):** if real it cannot be removed, if unreal there is nothing to remove.

Advaita replies throughout: the Vivaraṇa and Bhāmatī locations of ignorance; the cloud that obstructs the viewer, not the sun; grades measured by sublation (**bādhā**); witness-perception and postulation; the undivided-form mental mode; and cessation as the absolute simply remaining.

Examined, the force is uneven. The replies on concealment and cessation are strong; locus and means of knowing leave a genuine residue, since neither is settled without granting Advaita's own standpoint.

Why this earns marks. It names all seven with their technical terms inside a tight band, supplies the replies compactly, and answers the directive with a verdict on which objections actually survive.

Printed question. How is Brahman conceptualised in Advaita philosophy as both Nimitta and Upādāna Kāraṇa of the World? Discuss with suitable examples.

Directive read. The school is specified as Advaita, and examples are demanded explicitly. The examples must be interpreted, not merely named.

Model answer (284 words).

Efficient cause (**nimitta-kāraṇa**) is the intelligent agency that brings an effect about; material cause (**upādāna-kāraṇa**) is that out of which it is constituted. Ordinarily these are two things - potter and clay. Advaita collapses them into one, and the reason is negative before it is positive.

Since nothing exists independently of ultimate reality, there can be no second material out of which the world could be made. Ultimate reality must therefore be both the intelligence behind the world and the material basis of its appearance. The classic image is the **spider** spinning the web out of itself: one source supplies both the agency and the stuff, without recourse to anything external.

But the doctrine is immediately qualified by apparent transformation (**vivarta**). If ultimate reality really became the world, it would change, and a changing absolute is no longer unconditioned. The second image supplies the correction: the **rope and the snake**. The rope is the substrate of the snake-appearance without ever becoming a snake; it is not modified, yet nothing in the appearance is independent of it. "Material cause" therefore means *substrate*, not transformed stuff. Contrast **milk and curd**, where a real transformation genuinely alters the cause - the model Advaita rejects.

Two comparative lines complete the answer. Rāmānuja also makes ultimate reality both causes, but causation is real: subtle modes become gross. Madhva denies material causality of God altogether, assigning it to dependent primordial matter.

Critically, Rāmānuja objects that a substrate which never changes is not a material cause in any recognisable sense. The Advaitin's reply holds only if sublatability is accepted as a criterion of reality - which is where the dispute finally rests.

Why this earns marks. It defines both causes, gives the negative argument that motivates the identification, uses three examples as argument rather than ornament, qualifies with apparent transformation, and closes with the named objection and the criterion at stake.

Solved PYQ 20 - 2025, Question 8(a), 20 marks

Printed question. Discuss the idea of Bimba-pratibimbavāda as presented in Vedānta philosophy along with its soteriological significance.

Directive read. Two halves, explicitly. An ontological exposition without the soteriological significance forfeits roughly half the marks.

Model answer (400 words).

The model. The original-reflection model (**bimba-pratibimba-vāda**) takes ultimate reality or pure consciousness as the original (**bimba**) and the empirical self as its reflection (**pratibimba**) in the internal organ conditioned by ignorance. Its governing intuition is that the original remains unaffected by defects, motion or multiplicity in the reflecting media, as one face is unchanged though many mirrors - cracked, tilted, moving - yield differently conditioned images. Plurality is explained without dividing the absolute.

Its internal variants. Some later formulations distinguish the reflection of consciousness in total cosmic appearance as the Lord (**īśvara**), and its reflections in individual ignorance or internal organs as individual selves. Others treat the Lord as original relative to the individual, or prefer alternative models: limitation (**avaccheda-vāda**), in which one space appears as many pot-spaces (**ghaṭākāśa**), and semblance (**ābhāsa-vāda**), which stresses the ontological thinness of individuality. These are later explanatory alternatives rather than one uniform proposition attributable without qualification to Śaṅkara, and an answer should not assert that the Lord is simultaneously the original and a reflection without naming the model used.

Soteriological significance. The theory is not an ontological curiosity; it exists to make liberation intelligible. A reflection possesses no being of its own; it borrows all of it from the original. Therefore when ignorance is removed, nothing real is destroyed and nothing travels: the finite self is known never to have possessed independent reality apart from original consciousness. Liberation is accordingly recognition of non-difference, not the movement, merging or destruction of one substance by another. This supports the Advaita definition of liberation as attainment of what is already attained (**prāptasya prāptiḥ**), and explains why liberation while living (**jīvanmukti**) is possible: correcting a false claim requires no new production.

Critical assessment. The model's suggestive power should not be pressed as optics. A formless original, a formless medium and a non-dual reality make literal reflection impossible; reflection also normally requires a spatial gap between original and mirror, which non-duality forbids. Madhva uses the same original-reflection language to argue the opposite conclusion - that the dependent image is *really different* from its original - showing how far the metaphor under-determines the metaphysics.

The balanced verdict is that the model is an explanatory family with named variants: strong as a soteriological argument, weak as a literal account of how consciousness individuates.

Why this earns marks. It answers both halves in proportion, distinguishes the model's variants with the required attribution caution, ties the soteriology to the school's definition of liberation, and closes with a limit that includes a named rival use of the same metaphor.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Six original questions in the examination's own idiom - two at 10 marks, two at 15 and two at 20 - with complete model answers in the declared bands. These are learner practice, not previous-year questions.

Original 1 - 10 marks

Question. Distinguish between the dependently real (**mithyā**) and the wholly non-existent (**tuccha**) in Advaita Vedānta, and state why the distinction is indispensable.

Model answer (179 words).

The wholly non-existent (**tuccha**) is what is never presented in any experience - the standard examples are the hare's horn and the son of a barren woman. It cannot be cancelled, because cancellation presupposes a prior appearance.

The dependently real (**mithyā**) is what is presented and later sublated. The world appears, coheres, obeys laws and supports action, yet is denied independent, unsublatable reality; the rope's snake is presented vividly enough to cause flight and vanishes when the rope is recognised.

The distinction is indispensable for three reasons. First, without it Advaita collapses into nihilism, since "the world is unreal" would place the world where the hare's horn stands. Second, the middle grade is what makes sublation (**bādha**) meaningful: only what has appeared can be cancelled by knowledge. Third, it protects the empirical validity of ethics, scripture and the means of valid knowledge, all of which operate at the empirical level (**vyāvahārika**).

The cost, which critics press, is that a third ontological grade requires the sublation criterion that realists refuse to grant.

Why this earns marks. It defines both terms with their standard examples, gives three distinct reasons rather than one repeated, and ends with the objection that the distinction itself invites.

Original 2 - 10 marks

Question. "Nirguṇa does not mean blankness." Examine this claim with reference to Śaṅkara's conception of ultimate reality.

Model answer (191 words).

The claim is correct, and its defence turns on identifying what qualitylessness negates.

Qualityless (**nirguṇa**) denies limiting, relational, empirical and objectifiable attributes - the sort of predicates that would place the absolute as one item among knowable items. It does not deny nature. Being-consciousness-bliss (**sat-cit-ānanda**) is retained as the essential definition (**svārūpa-lakṣaṇa**), and it expresses the absolute's very essence rather than a list of accidental predicates added to a substrate. Determinate qualities such as creatorhood, omniscience, lordship and moral governance are not denied outright either; they are assigned to the Lord (**īśvara**), the absolute conditioned by illusion at the empirical level.

The claim also has a positive ground. The absolute is self-luminous (**svayaṃ-prakāśa**): it is not known as an object with predicates but is self-revealed as the condition of all knowing. A blank could not perform that function.

Examined critically, the defence holds internally but does not disarm Rāmānuja. If all cognition is of the qualified, a nature expressible by no determinate predicate is difficult to distinguish in practice from an unknowable, and Advaita must lean on self-luminosity rather than description.

Why this earns marks. It states what is negated and what is retained, supplies the positive self-luminosity ground, and concedes the precise point at which the rival objection retains force.

Original 3 - 15 marks

Question. Compare the accounts of the individual self offered by Śaṅkara, Rāmānuja and Madhva, and assess which best explains both bondage and moral responsibility.

Model answer (288 words).

Śaṅkara. The individual (**jīva**) is ultimate reality appearing finite through ignorance, explained by limitation (**avaccheda-vāda**, pot-space), reflection (**pratibimba-vāda**, the mirrored face) and semblance (**ābhāsa-vāda**). Bondage is superimposition (**adhyāsa**), not a real change in the self. Moral responsibility is fully binding at the empirical level and denied ultimacy.

Rāmānuja. The individual is a real, atomic, conscious mode (**prakāra**) inseparably dependent on ultimate reality, related as body to indwelling soul. Bondage is karmic obstruction contracting attributive consciousness (**dharma-bhūta-jñāna**); liberation removes the obstruction without removing the self.

Madhva. The individual is a real, distinct, dependent substance eternally different from God, with real difference among selves. Bondage is real ignorance and real karmic bondage; liberation is eternal service with gradation (**tāratamya**).

Assessment. On *bondage*, Śaṅkara's account is the most economical: it explains why bondage can end without anything real being destroyed, since a false identification simply lapses. Its difficulty is the locus of ignorance, which his own tradition answers in two incompatible ways. Rāmānuja's account is the most naturalistic - obstruction is a

matter of degree and admits gradual release - but it must explain why a real mode of a perfect God becomes obstructed at all.

On *moral responsibility*, the ranking reverses. Śaṅkara affirms obligation while denying its ultimacy, which critics read as weakening moral realism. Rāmānuja and Madhva keep the agent real throughout, and Madhva keeps difference constitutive, so responsibility is never provisional - at the cost of a permanent hierarchy among souls that strains moral universality.

The graded verdict: Śaṅkara explains bondage best, Madhva grounds responsibility most firmly, and Rāmānuja's inseparable dependence is the most balanced compromise between the two demands.

Why this earns marks. It compares on a common axis, splits the assessment by the two criteria the question names, and gives a graded verdict with each school's specific cost.

Original 4 - 15 marks

Question. "The disagreement between Vedānta's schools is finally a disagreement about the criterion of reality." Critically examine.

Model answer (282 words).

The claim is substantially correct, and testing it clarifies why the schools cannot refute one another directly.

Advaita's criterion is **sublation (bādhā)**: what is never sublated (**trikālābādhita**) is ultimately real; what is presented and sublated is dependently real; what is never presented is wholly non-existent. This single criterion generates the three levels of reality, the status of the world, the indescribability of illusion, and liberation as the removal of ignorance.

Rāmānuja's criterion is **qualified cognizability**: *sarvaṃ vijñānaṃ saviśeṣam*, all cognition is of the qualified. What cannot be cognised as qualified cannot be established. From this follow the rejection of a qualityless absolute, the reality of the world, and inseparable dependence (**apṛthaksiddhi**) as the way real modes can inhere in one substantive whole.

Madhva's criterion is **independence**: what is independent (**svatantra**) is supremely real, and whatever is dependent (**paratantra**) is nonetheless fully real. From this follow the reality of selves and world, fivefold difference (**pañcavidhabheda**), and the refusal of any grade between being and non-being.

This explains the structure of the debates. Rāmānuja's seven objections do not disprove ignorance; they show that it cannot be established on *his* criterion. Advaita's reply to Nyāya on error does not disprove realism; it shows an anomaly on the sublation criterion. Each school's strongest argument is therefore internal.

Critically, the thesis should not be over-generalised. The schools also disagree about scriptural hermeneutics - whether identity-sentences or difference-sentences govern - and about what a soteriology must deliver. But these disagreements track the criterion: a school that grades reality by sublation will read identity-sentences as literal, and one that grades it by independence will not.

Why this earns marks. It converts a broad claim into three named criteria, shows how each generates that school's doctrines, explains the dialectical stalemate, and qualifies the thesis instead of merely endorsing it.

Original 5 - 20 marks

Question. Evaluate the doctrine of indescribable illusion (**māyā**) as an explanatory principle, with reference to the objections it attracts and the replies available to Advaita.

Model answer (394 words).

What the doctrine claims. Illusion is the beginningless (**anādi**), dependent power through which a non-dual absolute appears as a plural world. It is neither being (**sat**) nor non-being (**asat**) but indescribable (**anirvacanīya**), and it exercises two powers: concealment (**āvaraṇa-śakti**), which hides the absolute's nature, and projection (**vikṣepa-śakti**), which throws up names and forms.

Its explanatory work. It performs four jobs simultaneously. It explains plurality without dividing the absolute; it explains bondage without a real change in the self; it explains why the world is coherent, public and law-governed while remaining sublatale; and, with superimposition (**adhyāsa**), it explains error by the same machinery that explains cosmology. Few principles in Indian philosophy are asked to do so much with so little ontological

commitment.

The objections. Rāmānuja's sevenfold charge presses at every seam. Its locus (**āśraya**) is untenable - in the absolute it defiles, in the individual it presupposes what it explains. It cannot conceal a self-luminous reality. Its nature is incoherent if it is neither real nor unreal. A third category is a refusal to answer. No means of valid knowledge establishes a positive ignorance. Neither its remover nor its cessation can be coherently specified. Madhva adds that a real world and real ignorance explain everything the doctrine explains, without the extra principle.

The replies. The Vivaraṇa school makes the absolute the locus without modification; the Bhāmatī school locates ignorance in the individual and appeals to beginningless mutual dependence. Concealment is relative to the viewer, as cloud to sun. The trichotomy is defended as grades of sublatability rather than as a violation of excluded middle. Witness-perception of "I do not know" and postulation from the fact that knowledge removes bondage are offered as means. The undivided-form mental mode removes ignorance and then subsides; cessation is the absolute simply remaining.

Evaluation. Judged as an explanation, the doctrine is powerful and economical: one principle, two powers, four explanatory jobs. Judged as an ontology, it is fragile at two points - the locus and the proof - where the replies presuppose the standpoint under dispute. The decisive issue is methodological: everything turns on whether sublatability grades reality. Grant it, and illusion is the most economical account of appearance available. Refuse it, and the doctrine names the problem of plurality rather than solving it.

Why this earns marks. It separates claim, explanatory work, objections, replies and evaluation; names the sub-schools; and locates the verdict in the criterion at stake rather than declaring a winner.

Original 6 - 20 marks

Question. "Every doctrine in the Vedānta clause is a settlement of one question: is the relation of the finite to the absolute identity, qualification or difference?" Discuss with reference to at least four printed syllabus terms.

Model answer (392 words).

The claim is a strong organising thesis, and testing it against four printed terms shows both its power and its limit.

The world (jagat). Under identity it is an apparent transformation (**vivarta**) - dependently real (**mithyā**) but not wholly non-existent, cancelled by knowledge of its substrate as the snake is by the rope. Under qualification it is real, the non-conscious (**acit**) dimension of the absolute's body, produced by a real transformation of modes from subtle to gross. Under difference it is real and eternally distinct, with God as efficient cause and dependent primordial matter as material cause. One question, three cosmologies.

The individual self (jīva). Under identity it is the absolute appearing finite through ignorance, explained by limitation, reflection or semblance. Under qualification it is a real atomic mode (**prakāra**) whose attributive consciousness contracts and expands. Under difference it is a real dependent substance, with difference among selves equally real.

Liberation (mokṣa). Under identity it is attainment of what is already attained (**prāptasya prāptiḥ**), admitting liberation while living. Under qualification it is unobstructed communion and service through devotion, surrender and grace. Under difference it is eternal service with gradation (**tāratamya**).

Inseparable dependence (aprthaksiddhi) and fivefold difference (pañcavidhabheda). These two terms are the thesis made explicit. The first names the settlement "qualification": real modes that cannot exist or be conceived apart from their substance - stronger than a conceptual relation, weaker than identity. The second names the settlement "difference": five real and eternal differences, including the two internal ones among souls and among material things that make plurality irreducible.

The limit of the thesis. Two qualifications are needed. First, the wider schools show that the three settlements are not exhaustive: Nimbārka treats difference and non-difference as equally real aspects of one relation, Vallabha proposes unchanged real manifestation (**avikṛta-pariṇāma**), and the Caitanya tradition treats the relation as inconceivable by finite reduction. Second, the settlements are downstream of a prior question - the criterion of reality - since sublation, qualified cognizability and independence generate identity, qualification and difference respectively.

The thesis therefore holds as a map of the clause and fails as a complete taxonomy. Its real value is examination-facing: it converts eleven printed terms into one question asked eleven times, which is exactly how a comparative answer should be built.

Why this earns marks. It applies the thesis systematically to four named syllabus terms, uses each school's technical vocabulary, and then limits the thesis with the wider schools and the prior criterion question instead of merely confirming it.